

TAMILNADU PEN MANUFACTURES
AND DEALERS ASSOCIATION

Presents

MORE THAN
100
STALLS

gift

STATIONERY & Office Expo

THE BIGGEST B2B EXPO FOR
CORPORATE GIFTING, PERSONAL GIFTING, AND RETURN GIFTS

18, 19 & 20
September, 2026

R.K CONVENTION CENTRE
Neelankarai, Chennai

GIFTING OPTIONS FROM
**Rs.10 to
1 LAKH**

CORPORATE GIFTS & PREMIUMS

OFFICE FURNITURE & SOLUTIONS

STATIONERY & OFFICE SUPPLIES

NETWORK & GROW YOUR BUSINESS

GROW YOUR BUSINESS NETWORK

EXCLUSIVE SHOW OFFERS & DEALS

CONECT WITH LEADING BRANDS

EXPOLRE LATEST PRODUCTS & TRENDS

FOR MORE DETAIL:
63812 71325

CATEGORIES

- APPARELS
- BOOKS, BAGS
- STATIONERY
- CORPORATE GIFTS
- PENS
- SUITCASE, TROLLEY

Powered by:-
Saino
PENS

In Association with
PIKMEE
Explore Your True Style

Media Partner
Bennett & Coleman
THE TIMES OF INDIA

Co-Sponsor
HERO

Travel Partner:-
ROSHAN

Powered By

VIRGIN POWER & ENGINEERING PVT.LTD.

Ve Charge

Franchise Partner

FRANCHISEPRENEUR

Media Pantner

TURNKEY EVENTS

THE TIMES OF INDIA

Co-sponsor

procharge

BUSINESS & FRANCHISE EXPO 2026

GRAND OPENING TODAY

MULTIPLE BUSINESS OPTIONS!

BE YOUR OWN BOSS!

DON'T MISS THIS OPPORTUNITY!

ENTRY TICKET RS.1000/- SCAN QR CODE FOR BOOKING

FOR MORE DETAIL: 98406 85048

R.K CONVENTION CENTRE Neelankarai, Chennai

19 & 20 September, 2026

EXPLORE MULTIPLE BUSINESS OPPORTUNITIES

DISCOVER FRANCHISE OPTIONS STARTING FROM 3 LAKHS TO 1 CRORE

In Association with

My VKC

My Store.

Technology Partner

extraa

pick of the week



Bite your way

Ciclo Café is taking its sandwich seriously with its new Sando Project, built around soft milk bread. The all-day menu stacks it with everything from bibimbap paneer, hash brown avocado and pesto buffalo mozzarella to egg, chicken keema, chilli chicken, piri piri chicken, miso chicken, chicken Caesar, truffle mayo mushroom and chicken, and beef fillet with mustard. *The sandos start from ₹300 onwards and can be found at all Ciclo outlets across the city.*



Eat Meghalaya

Take a culinary detour to Meghalaya as Chef Nambie Marak brings flavours from her Meghalayan heritage to Chennai. The three-day spread features vegetarian and non-vegetarian thalis with dishes like momo gujiya, banana flower and potato croquettes, Garo-style chicken pepper fry, chicken and black sesame, shrimp kapa, turmeric rice, black sesame ice cream, and black rice fritters. *₹2,000 onwards. Till September 20 at Raintree St. Mary's.*



Bodies unseen

At Lalit Kala Akademi, Akam – More Than What Meets the Eye features works by Monisha Subramaniam and Haripriya Gowrisankar exploring body image, beauty standards, and women's lived experiences. Monisha questions the “ideal body”, while Haripriya examines domestic labour, violence and the ways women are blamed, silenced, harassed, and targeted. *The exhibition is on until today at Lalit Kala Akademi, Greams Road.*



Looking back

T Viswanathan: A Retrospective, traces six decades of T Viswanathan's practice and his largely undocumented place within the Madras Art Movement. Featuring works in oil, tempera, and drawing, alongside his research into Indian miniature traditions, the retrospective follows his journey from his years under KCS Paniker to his Ganesha series and portraiture. *Till September 22, at Lalit Kala Akademi, Greams Road from 11am to 7pm.*



Sabya's New York

Twenty years after his New York Fashion Week debut, Sabyasachi Mukherjee returned to the city with denim, and a Met collaboration

Shweta Shiware

Twenty years ago, Sabyasachi Mukherjee went to New York with a collection called Snail, a move perversely quiet for a designer known for bohemia and handcraft: school uniforms, maternity wear, clean shapes, cotton and restrained embroidery, arguing for slowing down in an age of mass production. New York Fashion Week, he thought, would be the start of something; instead, it became a lesson in timing. His own account is blunt: too

ambitious, too little power. He promised himself he would return when the time was right. On Tuesday afternoon, he did. American supermodel Christy Turlington opened Bengal Byzantine Broadway in a denim-on-denim Canadian tuxedo, wearing high jewellery, a sly pairing of the everyday and the spectacular. A gold cuff set with garnet and tourmaline cabochons, its form borrowed from a 3rd Century Roman sarcophagus, moved up and down her wrist. A Byzantine animal panel elsewhere became a tiger-claw necklace, brown diamonds catching the light with

each step. Museum objects acquired bodies, gestures and attitude. “It was an homage to how Indians dress and how Americans dress,” Mukherjee said backstage, referring to the look as “a bridge between the East and the West”.

Denim meets embroidery

That ease came slowly. With the Save the Saree campaign around 2010, Mukherjee began experimenting with the sari's proportions, introducing the shorter Chotu Sabya Sari. By Big Love in 2015, his approach expanded into a wardrobe of jumpsuits, '70s little dresses, trousers and safari suits, silhouette over embroidery. By his 25th-anniversary show in Mumbai in 2025, the experiment had settled into practice. He called it an “introspection,” not a retrospective, building an imagined Calcutta around more than 150 looks made in West Bengal, with tartan trench coats and faux fur alongside

► Sabyasachi Mukherjee's Bengal Byzantine Broadway at New York Fashion Week; (below) model Christy Turlington in a denim Canadian tuxedo. REUTERS AND DAN LECCA

saris and familiar craft signatures. Turlington closed that show. By then, New York was the logical next step; Bengal Byzantine Broadway made its case in clothes rather than declarations. Japanese denim and British tweed, gingham and workwear, prairie dressing, cowboy and Panama hats, silk scarves and '70s bohemia met Bengal embroidery, beadwork and jewelled tiger motifs. Some embroidery masqueraded as tweed; draped skirts were worn over *bandhgalas*. On Instagram, Sabyasachi called it, “Bringing Americana to America.”

Of saris and kamarbands

Only one actual sari appeared on the runway, worn by model Avanti Nagrath near the end in black, styled with a wide belt and gold cuffs, cut close to eveningwear to look plucked from a red carpet. Actor Rani Mukerji, in the front row, wore a clear echo of it: the same drape with a sleeveless blouse, as spare as the one that had just walked. Everywhere else, the Chotu sari's logic appeared without the sari itself: at least seven looks featured wrap skirts knotted at the hip and slit to the thigh, their tuck and fall doing the work of a drape without the six yards. By the third or fourth, it was clearly deliberate. The jackets over them gave the game away, cropped hard at the ribs, stopping well short of the waist, a *choli's* logic, not a bolero's – the short upper layer lets the drape below set the shape. The sash made the same point differently. Mukherjee



tied one over a rust wrap skirt, another in black over a man's trousers, exactly where a cummerbund sits at a black-tie dinner. The cummerbund was never Western to begin with, making it a small joke at black tie's expense. The word comes from *kamarband*, the Indian waist sash that British officers adopted, later absorbed into Western evening dress. Every man in a cummerbund has been wearing a piece of India without knowing it.

Clothes built to survive

An Indian designer in New York, Paris or London does not need to arrive with an annotated glossary of India. He starts with clothes people already recognise and alters the grammar. Denim stays denim, gingham stays gingham, a cowboy hat needs no explanation. What changes is what sits beside it. “If you have to wear a dress and hire a bodyguard, don't come to me. If you wear my couture, get into an Uber,” Mukherjee said. The Met's multi-year collaboration extended this idea into jewellery: the first Byzantine-inspired chapter debuted alongside denim, tailoring and workwear. Even the title follows the same logic. Bengal is the lens, Byzantium the crossroads, and Broadway New York itself: commerce, immigration, spectacle and constant remix. The strongest looks shrugged off their references and simply became clothes. That's the distance from Snail. In 2006, Mukherjee arrived in New York hoping for entry into an international conversation. In 2026, he seems free of the burden of having to look Indian to be recognised as Indian. The irony is that the designer who first came to New York with a collection about slowing down has returned with a much larger luggage allowance. The clothes still carry India, they just don't announce it.

The writer is a columnist and critic, with a keen focus on fashion, textiles, and culture.

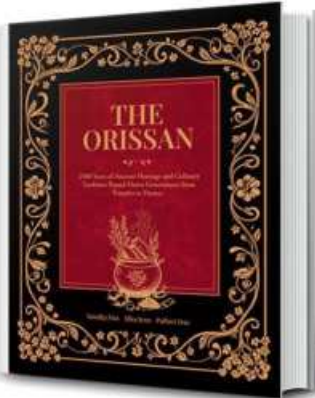


Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in

Alka Jena describes *The Orissan* (published by Penguin Random House India) as a “conversation between two generations”. More than a conventional cookbook, this recently released coffee-table book celebrates Odisha's rich gastronomic heritage by tracing traditions from temple kitchens, everyday families, and archival information. “We are often reduced to a handful of dishes or to the Jagannath tradition, when there is such incredible diversity within the State, from tribal food and temple cuisine to coastal produce, traditional crafts, festivals, architecture and the everyday lives of people,” says Alka, deputy director, Planning, Planning & Convergence Department, Government of Odisha, who has co-authored the book with father-daughter duo Sandip and Pallavi Das. The 350-page book offers chapters dedicated to Odisha's history, culture, temple foods, and recipes for starters, beverages, rice preparations, curries, festive puddings, and sweets.

Bridging the gap

With Alka based in Bhubaneswar, Pallavi in New York, and Sandip



in Gurugram, putting the book together involved multiple trips to Odisha, hours of research, and virtual meetings. “All of us being in different time zones, belonging to different generations, having different backgrounds and sensibilities has actually brought together a sense of perspective that bejewelled the book,” says Sandip, 68, who comes with



decades of corporate experience. Pallavi adds, “My father brought history and his extraordinary curiosity about Odisha; Alka brought the knowledge of someone deeply immersed in its kitchens, ingredients and culinary traditions; and I often came to it as an Odia who had grown up largely outside Odisha, asking

► (Clockwise from left) The pokhalo; Pallavi Das with Alka Jena; chhena poda; and the book cover. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



questions the diaspora might ask.”

The recipe bank

As for the detailed recipes, Alka says the ones close to her heart are the maccha haldipani made with fresh turmeric and buttermilk; saru patra besara, which is her grandmother's recipe featuring colocasia leaves; Sunday mutton curry that brings back childhood memories; and the chhena poda. Sandip considers the dalma as “the queen of dal” preparations. “Another unique dal is the habisa dali, and the santula is a simple mixed vegetable curry that's nutritious. I also cannot resist Odia non-vegetarian dishes like the patra poda (meat roasted on raw fire wrapped in sal leaves), mudi maunsa (puffed rice and slow-cooked mutton), soriso ilisi (mustard hilsa), and chuna machha chadchadi (spicy river anchovies),” he adds. But perhaps the most important lesson for Alka was personal: “Our mothers and grandmothers carried recipes, techniques and an understanding of seasons entirely through memory. Once a generation is gone, a recipe can disappear.” This book, she hopes, can slow that process.

Priced at ₹5,999, the book is available online

Memories of meethi seviyan



CONTINUED FROM
► PAGE 1

“Our project aims to be a multi-lingual open-access online archive of Indian culinary heritage,” says Ananya, an institutional research analyst at the University of Rhode Island, USA. The trio relies heavily on cookbook metadata and crowdsourced public knowledge, and is now trying to use AI APIs to create a more robust data archive of post-1900s published Indian cookbooks.

The power of memory

Prachi talks about how we are living in a time when families are more dispersed than ever, and therefore food is one of the easiest ways to hold on to identity and a sense of belonging. “Readers are increasingly drawn to stories that feel personal. Food memoirs and narratives offer an intimate way of understanding history through kitchens and shared meals,” she shares. Perhaps that is why it has become all the more important to not just revisit these traditions but document them. “Our lives have become so fast-paced that we rarely sit down together to eat anymore, and that matters more than it seems, because it's around a shared table that oral traditions get passed on. It could be



► Food is one of the easiest ways to hold onto identity and a sense of belonging. SHRADHA PARAKKAL AND APARNA PATIDAR

the labour of making winter pickles as a family, or mithai for festivals or weddings, or a simple family lunch,” says Samrata. As Kurush says, “Talk to your grandparents, parents and their generations in detail: about what they remember from childhood, what they ate on special occasions, and what was in their kitchens.” Things that are on my to-do list for this festive season, lest I lose another gem like the *meethi seviyan*.



mayhem

Director Tigmanshu Dhulia and Pratik Gandhi on *Ghamasaan*, why Tigmanshu doesn't like love stories, and Pratik's minimalistic approach to acting

Shreyas Pande
shreyas.pande@thehindu.co.in

“I find love stories too boring,” declares Tigmanshu Dhulia during a freewheeling conversation about his latest film, *Ghamasaan*. The filmmaker's voice carries a frustration similar to his much-quoted dismissal of cinema as the infamous Ramadhir Singh from Anurag Kashyap's *Gangs of Wasseypur*. And like Ramadhir, Tigmanshu is excited by the world of crime and politics, something he has explored right from his first film, *Haasil*.

With *Ghamasaan*, he returns to the world of dacoits, which he approached earlier with an earthy realism in *Paan Singh Tomar*. When asked what continues to attract him to this landscape, Tigmanshu is quick to chime in. “*Mera Mangal bohut strong hai* (I have a strong Mars in my horoscope),” he says, smiling, and explains that he is approached only to make films about dacoits and cops. “I have been an admirer of these films since I was a kid. If I was not a filmmaker, I would have been in the Army or police.”

He feels that there is a lot to explore in characters living in the hinterland. “I don't find urban characters as interesting, as people are not facing such conflicts in cities. Your surname doesn't matter here as much, but it is different in villages. So, when so much is happening in the world, why should I watch your love stories?,” he says.

The filmmaker is picky about other genres too. “I don't watch every Hindi movie,” he says. He has not seen some of Arshad Warsi's popular comedy films like the *Golmaal* series or *Hungama*. That is what made him look at Arshad differently when he decided to cast the actor as a dreaded dacoit in *Ghamasaan*. “I had seen him in *Sehar* and, of course, in *Munna Bhai MBBS*. So, I never looked at him as a comedian. I knew he is a very accomplished actor,” he says.

Training and theatre

Casting Pratik Gandhi was simpler, as the director had earlier worked with him on the mystery-thriller series, *The Great Indian Murder*. “I know his background in theatre, and I wanted someone who could improvise. I had a lot of faith in him and he suited the part pretty well too,” says Tigmanshu.

The *Scam 1992* and *Madgaon Express* actor maintains stunning restraint as an IPS officer in *Ghamasaan*, who is tasked with chasing the hyper-violent Maharaj (Arshad Warsi). Pratik instils an ordinariness in his performance, a quality that he uses to humanise all his characters. “I like minimalism a lot, with which you can communicate something that is written and anything that is not written as well. I like to give the audience a chance to interpret. That's what I like about the actor's life,” Pratik says.

Tigmanshu adds that an actor has to rise above the lines. “Dialogue delivery is not acting. What the person thinks before saying a line, that's acting,” he says.

The minimalism reflected in



(Clockwise from top) Tigmanshu Dhulia on the sets of *Ghamasaan*; and Pratik Gandhi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Pratik's performance has also been a definitive factor in the films of Tigmanshu – whether he gets into serious territory, like in his 2011 crime thriller *Shagird*, or goes pulpier, like in *Saheb, Biwi Aur Gangster* (2011). The same restraint is seen in *Ghamasaan*, where Tigmanshu relies more on the urgency of situations than on dramatic overtones. The filmmaker says he likes watching and making movies with those aesthetics. “It is easy to make hyper-dramatic films with loud background music, blood and butchery. I don't like to make my films that way,” he says.

Ghamasaan takes an old-school approach in how it operates without the usual tropes and still manages to engage to a large extent. An important action sequence midway functions without reliance on any background score, which further accentuates the after-effects of violence. “It is the lull before the storm which is terrifying. There were moments like that even in *Sholay*, where suspense was created with just the sound of footsteps,” he says. The actor opines that the change in storytelling in recent years reflects a lack of confidence that

makers have in their work. “I have been seeing these days that, by design, we are creating second-screen experiences. We are scared of pauses and are filling it up with voice-overs and music because we feel the audience will go away.”

Tigmanshu agrees. “If you make a good film, people will watch,” he says.

Ghamasaan is streaming on Zee5

György Pálfi, the Hungarian filmmaker, on the eight chickens starring in *Hen*, Hungary's film politics, and knowing your dinner intimately

Chicken, camera, action



(Above) A still from the film *Hen*; (below) György Pálfi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

A chicken makes perfect sense as a György Pálfi protagonist. With a filmography of oddities spanning *Hukkle* (2002), *Taxidermia* (2006) and *Final Cut: Ladies and Gentlemen* (2012), the Hungarian filmmaker has had a curious knack for making the patently bizarre feel perfectly matter-of-fact. But even by his standards, *Hen* sounds rather eccentric. The latest feather in his cap appears to take its cue from the age-old question: why did the chicken cross the road? Why, to escape an industrial poultry farm in Greece and bust a human-trafficking operation, of course.

The chicken is certainly the hook, but György is after something considerably more philosophical here. “Yes, there is a chicken and the chicken is the main hero,” he says, “but there is also a human story.” The two seem inseparable for him. “I always wanted to find the answer to this question in my movies: how much of us is animal, and what makes us human?” he says. “Why is

the human a different animal? Or is the human simply another animal? Is the human a different kind of creature on earth?”

The chicken's appearance was also dictated by the world she comes from. György wanted her to be recognisably an industrial bird, so he began by looking at the breeds used in commercial poultry production. The whiteness of the conventional Leghorn chicken posed a practical problem: how does an audience keep track of one chicken among many? His solution was to make the protagonist black, turning her into what he calls an “industrial or evolutionary mistake”. The production eventually settled on a black Australorp-Leghorn type of chicken, and the animal trainer bought 15 young birds from a farm. Eight would eventually make the journey to Greece.

The casting process eventually became a division of labour. Each chicken had a particular aptitude, which meant that the protagonist was effectively played by a small ensemble of birds, called upon according to what a scene required. One could run particularly fast. Another could remain in the

same spot for hours. Another had learned to peck on command. Then there was Feri, the chicken who seemed to have a knack for everything. “Whenever the others couldn't do something, we called Feri and said, ‘Come on, this is your job. The others can't do it.’”

The more remarkable part of the process was how little of it depended on forcing the birds to perform. György credits their animal trainer, Árpád Halász, with earning the hens' trust long before they reached the set. “He made a very safe environment for them. We humans became friends with these animals, and they became friends with us,” he says. By the time the eight hens reached Greece, they were already comfortable around people and the routines of the set. “They were so calm,” György says. “They were like colleagues. They were very collaborative and very open. They weren't afraid of humans at all.”

After spending all these years studying chickens, I ask the obvious question: does he still eat them?

“Eating chicken meat is the easiest thing, because I know them well,” he says.

His research seems to have made him less sentimental about the species. He describes chicken society as “very strange and rough”, with “a very cruel hierarchy system”. He began wondering what humans might look like from the other side of the food chain. “If our positions were swapped, and chickens were the apex predators of the world while humans were just food, they would eat us, no question.” He had the thought during filming, when familiarity made the birds seem increasingly vivid. “I was thinking, why do I eat chicken? They are such nice, intelligent, beautiful animals,” he says. “But when I better understood how they live, I thought, if I were a chicken, I would eat humans. So I can eat chicken.”

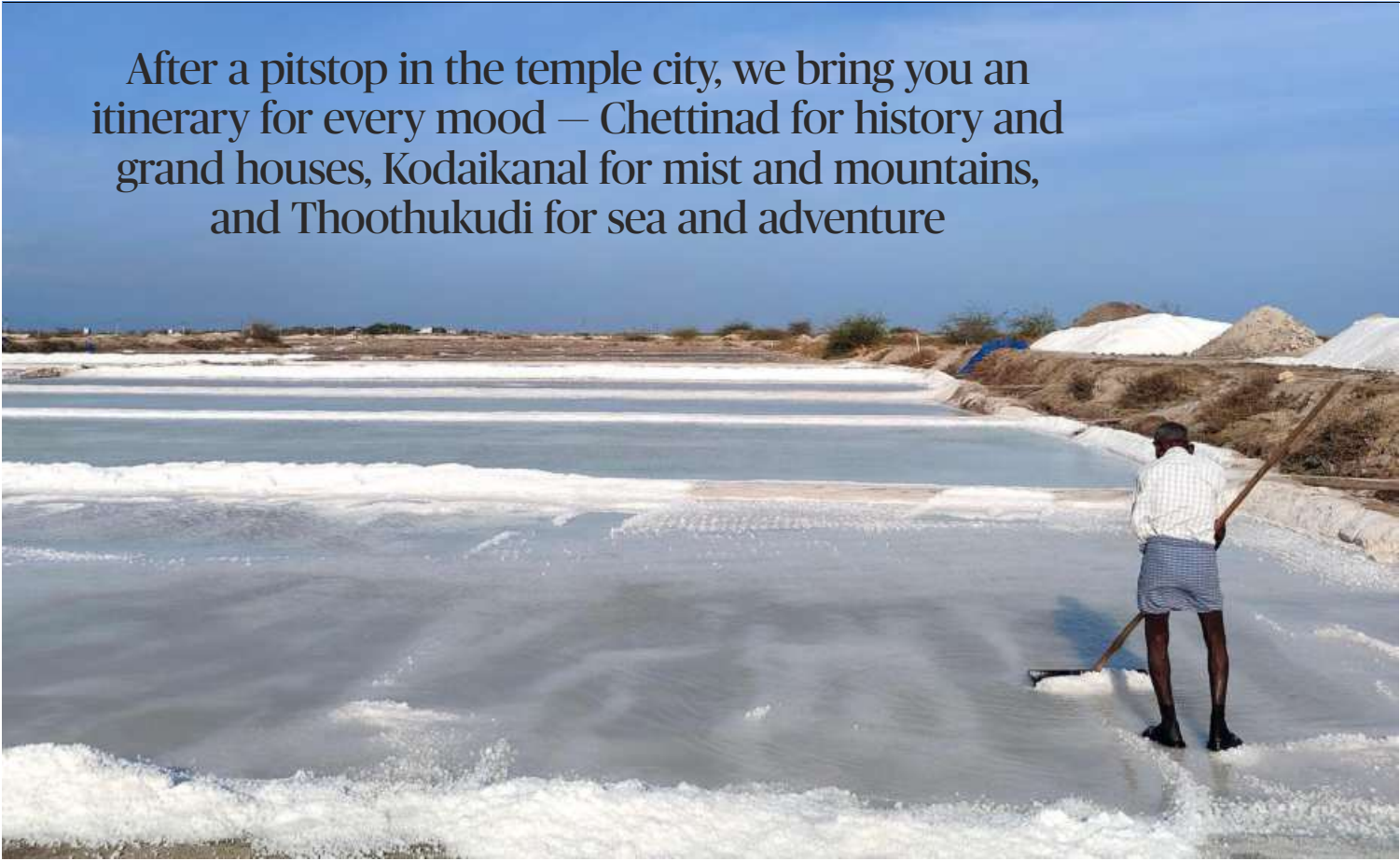
He recommends trying Hungarian paprika goulash as the only valid response to this existential quandary. “But your kitchens in India are so much richer than here in Hungary.” It's an appropriately Pálfi-esque place to leave things.

Hen is currently available to rent or buy on BookMyShow Stream

THE OCTOBER THEATRE FEST PRESENTS
EARLY BIRD SPECIAL OFFER
EXTERNAL AFFAIRS
LOVE. TECH. CONFUSION. CHAOS. WELCOME TO THE NEW GENERATION.
Written by Bobby Nagra | Directed by Adhaar Khurana
2ND OCT 2026 @7PM | SIR MUTHA VENKATASUBBA RAO CONCERT HALL (LADY ANNAL CAMPUS, CHENNAI)
GOLD CATEGORY
PROMO CODE: OTF2EA GSPL
SCAN TO BOOK NOW

JCS JEWEL CREATIONS | calonge hand braided leather accessories
Bringing together brands from across India.
25 Years of Duchess Utsav
Fashion | Jewellery | Food | Home Décor | Accessories
Lifestyle | Organic Products & much more
Your favourite Shopping Festival is back!
25th & 26th SEPTEMBER 2026 | Savera Hotel Chennai 10 AM - 8 PM

AYUDHA POOJA & DIWALI Orders Accepted
Festival Orders Booking Contact
78248 87732 / 92824 44888
89398 78733 / 89398 78735
TRADITION SINCE 1981
Ps4 Perambur Sri Srinivasa Sweets & Snacks
RESTAURANT
perambur_sri_srinivasa | perambur_sri_srinivasa | Mail: info@perambursrinivasa.com | www.perambursrinivasa.com



PHOTOS: ABHINAV VINAYAKH SHANKARNARAYANAN AND S POORVAJA

Kodaikanal- 120 KMS VIA BATLAGUNDU

When you reach Batlagundu in Dindigul, on the way to Kodaikanal, the air already begins to feel different. There is a faint nip in the breeze; the highways give way to narrower roads flanked by sprawling fields and coconut groves, and a pit stop to sip on *elaneer* while taking in the view feels almost essential. Kodaikanal can get crowded during peak season, public holidays, long weekends and the summer months, and yet, is one of those rare places that has managed to retain most of its charm. Its residents will tell you that they are sometimes worried about the incessant littering, noisy tourists and how increasingly commercial it all is, and yet, there is so much about this sleepy town and its many misty corners that rejuvenates many weary urban souls. Rashmika Johanna, a Kodaikanal resident who opened Kodai In a Box, a farm experience with her husband Ajith Christian around three years ago, says that at her farm, visitors, especially



children, have much to do. “There are farm animals, passion fruit creepers, and a variety of local vegetables grown here. Children can pick veggies and fruits and feed our animals, brew a cup of spearmint tea with freshly plucked leaves and more,” she says. Experiencing Nature is such an important part of visiting the hill station that Rashmika says the farm too, has as little intervention as possible. “We haven’t

changed much here or built large structures, our old pear trees are undisturbed, and there is a sense of calm here,” she adds. For visitors making a beeline to Kodaikanal, Rashmika suggests a visit to the pine forest for those Instagrammable photos. For the more adventure-loving souls, she highlights a trek down to see Dolphin’s Nose at Vattakanal, a post-trek meal at Altaf’s Cafe, and a pitstop at the scenic Pambar falls enroute. “The majestic tree and Guna caves are now very popular after *Manjummel Boys*, but did you know, there is a 500-year-old jamun tree at Shola Road,” Rashmika says. “The Shenbaganur Museum of Natural History is a common field trip spot for schools here, and is definitely worth a visit. A drive to Poombarai, with scenic views of the town and a visit to the Mannavanur lake are must-dos as well,” she adds. When hunger strikes, slices of oven fresh pizza from George’s Gourmet Kitchen, now at a new location with lovely views, is on her list as well.

S Poorvaia
poorvaia.sundar@thehindu.co.in

Often compared to Manhattan as a ‘city that never sleeps’, Madurai has earned a reputation for its ceaseless hustle. More so, over the last few weeks, with the lead up to the consecration ceremony of the Madurai Meenakshi temple after 17 years, which on Thursday, attracted thousands of people to witness the historic milestone and revel in the fervour of it all. Long referred to as the gateway to South Tamil Nadu, Madurai makes a great starting point for exploring what lies beyond – bolstered by smooth highways, scenic routes, and, of course, coffee pit stops. We give you our pick of quick gateways from the temple city, and hear from locals who are happy to share their favourites, which include scenic spots, special meals and more.

Thoothukudi- 150 KMS

Thoothukudi is where one heads for stunning views of the sea. The Subramanya Swamy temple at Thiruchendur, perched right by the sea, has pilgrims thronging through the year, as does the Our Lady of Snows Basilica, with its much anticipated annual festival in August. For more dramatic views of the Bay of Bengal, head to the Holy Cross Church on a cliff, in the scenic coastal town of Manapad dotted with pristine beaches. To go beyond the views and get close and personal with the sea, Aqua Outback, a resort and water sports academy, has kayaking, snorkelling, kite surfing and more at the azure waters of the Gulf Of Mannar. Adventures are not mandatory, there is also plenty of nothing to do by the sea, with a book, a cold beverage in hand, some fresh seafood and a cheese platter for company. “Thoothukudi is a small, closely-knit community where everyone takes care of each other. Food is central to all experiences; weddings in particular have a

ridiculous amount of food and I remember this from my own wedding here as well. It was the first time I experienced such hospitality,” says Anaina K Motha, head, Events and Marketing, Aqua Outback. Her husband Arjun Motha, a pro kiteboarder, founded Aqua Outback in 2015 and Anaina moved to Thoothukudi six years ago. Anaina says a typical date night for her would be at Aandavar, for their famed parottas, or Aardvark Cafe, for a more upscale, laid-back evening. “There is Prema Mess of course, and so many other places that are either gems that have been around for decades, or a smattering of newer establishments driven by the need to have a variety of cuisines,” she explains. While Dhanalakshmi Bakery and Ganesh Bakery’s airy Thoothukudi macaroons, a crunchy sweet treat made of egg whites, crushed cashews and a generous helping of sugar are a staple souvenir to take back from the port city, Anaina also recommends coconut biscuits, *kuchhi mittai*, and mutton puffs. As one of the country’s largest salt-producing hubs, Thoothukudi is also a good place to pick up salt from local manufacturers, she adds.

Karaikudi-90 KMS

There is no better time to explore Chettinad than when you are ready for a crash course in art, history, culture and, of course, food; one that you will inevitably wish had lasted a little longer. A cursory glance at any travel recommendation online will wax eloquent about the region’s beautiful mansions and intricate carvings on Burma teak wood, its Athangudi tiles and its food (which there are many imperfect variations of outside the region). Chettinad is also currently hosting the annual Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival. For Adithi Ganeshan, gemologist and founder of jewellery brand Thamalli, a great place to begin exploring the history of the region is Pettagam, a private museum of Chettinad jewellery, where she also serves as creative director. “The museum talks about the history of the Nagarathar community, their migration and how they settled in what we see today as Chettinad. The space also traces how our unique style of jewellery is integral to Nagarathar culture,” she says. The soon-to-open Museum of Chettinad, housed in culture revivalist Visalakshi Ramaswamy’s 125-year-old family home in Kanadukathan, will also offer, she says, a nuanced insight into the region’s history, traditions and architecture, as well as revived crafts such as kottan, or palm-leaf basket weaving, and Chettinad (kandangi) saris. “The Athangudi palace, an architectural marvel, is one of the most beautiful Chettinad houses I have seen and a must-visit,” Adithi says. Once you are done



admiring the many different Athangudi tile patterns, she recommends visiting a factory where the tiles are made, and trying your hand at making them as well. “No visit to Chettinad is complete without a lunch at The Bangla,” she adds. A full meal at The Bangla, complete with its kootu, kozhambu, mutton curry and crowning glory, ghee ice cream for dessert, is an essential myth buster; Chettinad cooking is nuanced, flavourful and not simply spicy, as many believe it to be. For a spiritual experience, Adithi suggests heading to the famous Pillaiyarpatthi temple, which has its deity in the form of a natural, monolithic idol.



Kuda Huraa, rooted in the five elements, sits alongside Reefscapers’ coral restoration, turtle conservation, and marine research

Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in

If there was a year to travel for wellness, 2026 would be it. From longevity retreats and spiritual journeys to digital detox camps and naturopathy sanctuaries, travellers have been increasingly seeking vacations that rejuvenate the mind and body alike. During my recent sojourn to the Maldives, I dived deep into the latter: a dedicated wellness retreat on a private islet: the Four Seasons Resort Maldives at Kuda Huraa, a quick 25-minute speedboat ride from Male airport. At the heart of their wellness-focussed offerings is Urja (meaning vitality in Sanskrit), an island that launched in December 2025. Helmed by naturopathy physician Anand Prayaga, Urja is rooted in naturopathic principles centred on the five elements, aka pancha mahabhutas: earth, water, fire, air, and space. Highlights include sound healing, anti-gravity yoga, yoga therapy, and a range of massages. To experience their offerings, I head to Urja aboard a dhoni – a



traditional ornate Maldivian multi-purpose wooden boat – which is a few minutes from the main island of the resort. A consultation with Girinathan Santhisathram, wellness curator at Urja, leads to a relaxing hour experiencing a massage while looking at the emerald waters. “Everything we experience is linked to the five elements of Nature, and we use them to treat the body,” explains Anand, director, Urja, over dinner at Baraabaru, the resort’s Indian restaurant. It has been seven months since its official launch, but he still calls Urja a “work in

progress”. “A new food menu that spotlights the naturopathy diet is in the works, and this will soon be available in all the restaurants at Kuda Huraa.” The property’s Marine Discovery Centre (MDC) is led by a team of passionate marine biologists from Maldivian marine consultancy Reefscapers, which has been working to restore coral reefs in the Maldives since 2005. Their pioneering coral frame technique was launched in 2001, and since then, thousands of frames have been planted across the Maldives. As I attach coral fragments to a large frame, marine biologists Kathryn Pogson and Aditya Salvi tell me the frames are made with iron rebar, which is coated with sand and resin. “Coral reefs cover less than 1% of the ocean floor, yet support 25% of marine life,” shares Aditya, adding that they will soon have a spawning lab at the centre where “we will raise baby corals and release them to the ocean once they are ready”. There are 3,291 coral frames at Kuda Huraa, and over 10,000 across the four resorts Reefscapers works at in the Maldives. As I snorkel around the

(Clockwise from left) The dhoni, a traditional ornate Maldivian multi-purpose wooden boat; a snapshot of the MDC’s sea turtle rescue and rehabilitation programme; and a coral frame being planted. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



island, the ocean bed is peppered with these thriving frames, some shaped as stars, Christmas trees, and hearts. This year also marks two significant milestones for the resort: 15 years of the Sea Turtle Conservation Programme, and the planting of the resort’s 9,000th coral frame in partnership with Reefscapers. The marine conservation initiatives go beyond the corals: there is a sea turtle rescue and rehabilitation programme, and a fish lab to study local marine species. A pleasant addition to my itinerary to experience one such species is a dolphin cruise. Aboard a speedboat with experts from MDC, we set off on a two-hour trip across Kuda Huraa’s crystal clear waters, spotting several pods of spinner dolphins leaping in the waves. On my first snorkelling adventure, Wiaam, a student volunteer at the resort, told me he first snorkelled when he was five. “I just love everything about the water!” he said, guiding me through the water. “Remember to breathe, and don’t flap your hands around too much.” A lesson for life, methinks.

The writer was in the Maldives on invitation from The Four Seasons Resort Maldives at Kuda Huraa

HattaKatta
PREVENTIVE CARE
Stay Strong. Stay Independent. Stay You.

ONE TAP. ONE ALERT. PEACE OF MIND.

A wearable that watches out for your parents — even when you can't.

FALL ALERT & SOS

The moment a fall happens, help is already on the way.

ALERTS, YOUR WAY

Get instant WhatsApp alerts, plus deeper insights anytime on the HattaKatta app.

ONE SIMPLE PRICE

₹8,499 for the watch. Just ₹99/month for WhatsApp & app alerts.

GIVE THEM SAFETY. GIVE YOURSELF PEACE OF MIND.

₹8,499 - Device Only | ₹99/month - App Subscription

CALL / WHATSAPP 94455 73195

Text "SAFE" to WhatsApp to order your today

support@hattakatta.in

www.hattakatta.in

AGS THIRAR | AGS MADURAVOYAL | AGS VILLIVAKKAM | AGS OMRI | PR MALL WALTAX ROAD | IDREAMS | SHARATH | KRISHNAVENI MAYAJAAL ECR | ROHINI KOYAMBEEDU | VETRI CHROMPET | RAKKI & MURUGAN AMBATUR | GREEN & SIVASAKTHI PADI | SHANMUGA MOOLAKKADAI | VARADARAJA CHITLAPAKKAM | MIRAJ PERUMBARKAM | MEENAKSHI AVADI | GOPALAKRISHNA PORUR | VELAN NANDANMALLUR VIJAY PARK NAMBARKAM | RADHA REDHILLS | MANI & KK NINJUR | RAKKI THIRUVALLUR, KELAMBARKAM | MMM THIRUVALLUR | C3 MANANDUR VELS CHEMBARKAMBARKAM | MVR GUOVANCHOERY | SEVEN SCREEN KILAMBARKAM | SRK CHEVALPATTU | SANTHALINGAM ORASADAM LAKSHMIBALA PADI | GANGA KOLATHUR | BABU & ARUNA KANCHEPURAM | VELA THIRUNNIDRAVUR | GANESH & VELCO ANAKAPATTURTHUR

SUPER HIT!

SANDAKARI

THE BOSS

PRODUCED BY PUNNAGAI POO GHEETHA

R.R.GURUDHEV - AMRISH - DINESH - KANAL KANNAN - ADEE R.K. - VIVEKA - MADHAN KARKY - ARYAPPAN - PERUMAL SELVAM JAYAKRISHNA - AMBIAKAPATHY - SATHISH (AJM) - HORSE

Malayalam

A mystery that fizzles out after initial promise



SR Praveen
praveen.sr@thehindu.co.in

At times, one or two sequences are all it takes to turn an otherwise unremarkable movie into a worthwhile experience. A memorable shot or a standout performance can almost make one forget the rest of its failings. The scene involving Urvashi's titular character and a doctor in Safar Sanal's *Aasha* could have become a run-of-the-mill emotional sequence of a mother realising that something dreadful might have happened to her daughter.

But Urvashi lends an uncommon depth to the scene, with a performance that is not just a portrayal of a mother's anguish over the immediate event, but also her own already frayed mental state. The way she lets stuttered words escape her lips, the voice modulation she employs, or even the way she fails to steadily hold a pen to sign a document, all come together to paint a picture of the ocean of worry within her.

Aasha, the character, spends much of the film in such a disturbed mental state, right from a tense encounter at a bank in the opening scene to the worries about her daughter Anagha's (Aishwarya Lekshmi) marriage. One of the rare instances she smiles is in the presence of her neighbour (Vijayaraghavan). Even so, she has a relatively normal existence until a dispute over a road accident with Jeemon (Joju George).

For a while, the film teases the prospect of a battle of egos – similar to *Ayyappanum Koshiyum* (2020) – between Aasha and Jeemon. Halfway through, it takes a much darker turn. That is where the screenplay, co-written by Joju, Ramesh Girija and Safar Sanal, fizzles out too. Much like Aasha, who created this particularly difficult situation from which she cannot find any way of wriggling out, the screenwriters seem clueless as to the ways to untangle the situation. The abrupt, unsatisfactory end of the film further underlines this fact.

The primary conflict in the film is also on weak footing. Aasha's drastic actions arise from certain assumptions about a situation, but it does not turn out to be a surprise for the audience when she finally realises the big picture. Some other sequences too seem contrived for cinematic conveniences. The music, the sound design (by Ajayan Adat, who plays a key character too), and other technical departments combine well to accentuate the dark mood in the later portions of the film. However, without ample support from the writing department, these do not leave the desired impact.

In the end, one is left only with Urvashi's intense performances in some of the sequences, like a cricketer playing the lone stellar innings in a losing cause, a knock of such beauty that the result of the match becomes irrelevant. It again makes one realise how underutilised she has been recently in Malayalam cinema. If only the film had something more solid to back her, we might have had a gem of a movie.

Aasha is currently running in theatres.



Portrait of middle-class desperation

Adapting Aravind Adiga's novel, Ben Rekhi builds a gripping moral battleground where a community chooses redevelopment to compromise its own foundation

Hindi

Anuj Kumar
anuj.kumar@thehindu.co.in

At the heart of *Last Man in Tower* lies Vishram Cooperative Housing Society, a decaying, close-knit enclave of middle-class Mumbai families. Their world is upended when a ruthless real estate tycoon, Dharmen Shah (Boman Irani), offers them a life-changing financial windfall to buy out the building for luxury redevelopment. The catch is that the payout is all or nothing, contingent on a unanimous vote. While his cash-strapped neighbours eagerly scramble for a ticket into the modern world, Yogesh Mishra (Manoj Bajpayee), a retired schoolteacher known as Masterji, stubbornly refuses to sign away the home that holds the memories of his deceased wife. What begins as a disagreement quickly degenerates into a psychological social pressure cooker, as the neighborhood's collective desperation, led by the chirpy Sangeeta Puri (Divya Dutta), turns into targeted malice against the lone dissenter.

Directed by Ben Rekhi, this study of greed, based on Aravind Adiga's eponymous English novel, probes whether rapid urbanisation and privatisation truly push society forward, or simply widen the chasm between people, ruthlessly muzzling the moments and memories that once held them together. The lucrative offer transforms cooperative neighbours into suspicious adversaries. The narrative depicts the moral collapse and asks how easily peer pressure, fear, and financial temptation can turn ordinary people against dissenting neighbours.

The police pay little heed to his harassment, the legal system bogs him down in official delays, and the local machinery works as an extension of the developer. The visual of Masterji systematically crossing out the primary pillars of democracy from his notepad is the film's most devastating symbolic sequence. The bemused builder can't put

Last Man in Tower

Director: Ben Rekhi

Cast: Manoj Bajpayee, Divya Dutta, Boman Irani, Sukant Goel

Synopsis: When a retired schoolteacher stubbornly refuses to sell his flat despite a lucrative real estate redevelopment offer, his resistance pits him against his own neighbours.



Scan the QR Code for more entertainment news.

a price on Masterji's soul, but when his son (Sukant Goel is impressive) also sees him as a wall unyielding to the future, the betrayal cuts to the bones. Rekhi emphasises the decaying, lived-in texture of the housing society and uses it as a visual metaphor. The camera lingers on the menacing scale of vertical ambition and also captures the shrinking of Masterji's world.

That said, Adiga's tragicomic tone often lives in the internal contradictions, hypocrisies, and petty thoughts of the building's residents. Cinema naturally externalises internal thoughts. Sooni Taraporevala, who has masterfully adapted some big books before for screen, keeps the soul intact, and Juhi Chaturvedi's dialogues keep the situations lifelike in translation, but there are passages where the neighbours' petty bickering and escalating cruelty play out as straight, tense drama rather than dark comedy.

Moreover, when Adiga conceived this story, Mumbai's redevelopment boom was in its infancy, a contentious, evolving phenomenon that still invited diverse points of view. Today, that boom has solidified into an irreversible, institutionalised process. This structural shift in the real world leaves the film's central conflict feeling somewhat jaded, as in the contemporary real estate landscape, the battle for spaces like the Vishram Society has already been decisively fought, lost, and laid to rest.

It works more as a he-said-so, for we can see around us a growing submission of the middle class to the whims of the market and surrender to the bully next door. It makes us feel the pain of shrinking community spaces, where the loss of common ground inevitably narrows the human heart within.

Manoj is being Manoj. Masked behind thick-rimmed glasses and armed with a ubiquitous umbrella, the actor portrays Masterji's defiance with exhausting dignity. As someone in danger of being swept away by the modern world, his performance rests on slumped shoulders, heavy sighs, and eyes that register deep betrayal every time a lifelong neighbour turns against him. While Masterji doesn't have the poetic depth of Prof Siras (*Aligarh*), the

teacher who perhaps taught physics is as compelling in the gravity of his conviction.

The schoolteacher has served as a vital ideological anchor in Hindi cinema, a principled figure deployed to resist cosmetic change and moral decay. If this film had been made a decade ago, Anupam Kher would have been the quintessential choice for Masterji. Watching the film brought back memories of Anupam's iconic roles in *Saraansh* and *Salaakhen*, but in Adiga's ruthless universe, the traditional narrative catharsis is dismantled. Here, the righteous old schoolteacher finds no humble student willing to rise to the occasion and defend his ideals. Similarly, the classic trope of a son avenging his father's humiliation is entirely inverted. Manoj is alive to this structural cynicism and to his rigid, borderline irrational pride, which Adiga's text reflects, even if the screen time doesn't allow enough to develop the character's psychological layers fully.

The screenplay does deliver a sobering truth. The traditional hero is obsolete, and no singular villain exists to fight. The antagonist is the collective desperation of the middle class. The neighbours are not malicious monsters. They are ordinary families suffocated by the urban grind. They feel one old man's rigid principles stand directly in the way of their only shot at a better life. Divya Dutta represents this threat next door. She keeps Mrs. Puri from becoming a caricature. As the mother of a disabled child who loves to spend time with Masterji, she brilliantly voices the ambiguity of human relations and the simmering hostility of the Vishram Society because her malice feels justified from her perspective.

While Boman Irani consciously distances himself from the loud, comedic villainy of *Khosla Ka Ghosla* to deliver a sleeker brand of corporate greed, pushing the envelope here is an uphill battle. The writing and world-building trap Boman in a familiar mould, much like the central conflict, making it hard for his real estate tycoon to outrun the shadow.

Last Man In Tower is currently running in theatres.

A taut thriller that rarely has a misstep

Malayalam

SR Praveen
praveen.sr@thehindu.co.in

It may be one of cinema's greatest tricks that it can twist one's line of thinking about a person or an incident just with the perspective it chooses to present, the framing, editing choices, or the background score used. Reading a basic news report on the incident of crime at the centre of Shahad's *Pradhama Drishtiya Kuttakkar* might make one assume a particular stand on the culprits, knowing the long history of this kind of crime in the country and the stories that can be made up to save them.

However, the film frames the incident, the events leading up to it, its aftermath and the people involved in such a way that not once do we wish for the culprits to be caught and punished. Of course, we have Jeethu Joseph's *Drishyam* (2013), in which we all collectively stood with those who committed the



crime. The film also has quite a few parallels with *Drishyam*, but this one has very different concerns and approach to the crime.

For much of the film, we see the whole incident through the eyes of Aleena (Parvathy), who gets a job in the police department on compassionate grounds after her husband's death and through her close-knit group of lower-rung

officers, Divya (Unnimaya Prasad), Dasan (Sidharth Bharathan) and Sreenath (Mathew Thomas). Halfway through, we also see it from the perspective of Haris Meeran (Vijayaraghavan), a crime branch officer whom we know as one of the sharpest brains in the force.

Despite our longtime habit of wishing for such invincible officers to crack tough cases, we wish for

him to lose this one.

Shahad, who debuted with the forgettable coming-of-age drama *Prakashan Parakkatte* (2022), ups his game here by several notches, aided by a taut screenplay he co-wrote with P.S.Subramaniam and Vijesh Thottingal and top-notch work from cinematographer Roby Varghese Raj and music composer Majeed Majeed. Although there are some

conveniences that the writers resort to, these do not hamper what appears to be an organically progressing plot, which manages to keep us on the edge for much of the close to three-hour runtime. The ways in which the film uses a book written by one of the characters to

further the plot is perhaps one of the highlights.

Amid the tense encounters inside the police station, where a good part of the film is set, the writers find space for some much-needed humour to ease the tension. These are so cleverly sneaked in and often have a bearing on the core plot that they don't seem out of place in a thriller of this nature. Parvathy lends much-needed emotional depth to her character, which she plays with a convincing mix of the circumspection of a relative newbie in the force and the sure-footedness of someone who has a strong reason to survive, whatever the odds. On the other hand, Vijayaraghavan radiates awe as an investigator in front of whom even the perfect crime unravels.

Just when a number of police procedurals in Malayalam seemed to be following the same narrative beats, *Pradhama Drishtiya Kuttakkar* injects the genre with some novelty.

Pradhama Drishtiya Kuttakkar is currently running in theatres

Fall 2: Deadpoint

Director: The Spierig Brothers

Starring: Harriet Slater, Arsema Thomas, Tom Brittney, Virginia Gardner

Storyline: Two young women set off to conquer the plank walk in Thailand when a landslide puts paid to their well-laid plans



Time to eat your fears again

English

Mini Anthikad Chhibber

mini.chhibber@thehindu.co.in

The fear of falling is an elemental one, running contrary to the human desire to conquer heights. Sir Edmund Hillary famously said, “It is not the mountain we conquer, but ourselves.” Scott Mann’s 2022 survival thriller, *Fall*, is built on these opposing human impulses.

In the film, two friends, Shiloh (Virginia Gardner) and

Becky (Grace Caroline Currey) decide to climb an abandoned 2,000-foot TV tower. Shiloh climbs all sorts of scary heights to create content for her social media account while Becky agrees to the join her to come to terms with her husband’s death a year before in a trekking accident. After being stranded at the top of the tower for a few days, Becky makes it down alone.

Fall 2: Deadpoint begins with Jax (Harriet Slater) grieving the death of her sister, Shiloh. She meets Shiloh’s friend, Luce (Arsema Thomas), who convinces Jax to accompany her to Thailand for the “plank walk” on Mount Kwan.

The plank walk, inspired by the cliff-side trail on Mount Hua in China, is basically a series of rickety planks circling the mountainside at 4,000 feet (double the height of *Fall*’s 2,000 foot TV tower) and ending at the scariest, flimsiest bridge over a yawning canyon. At the end of the walk is a statue of a

dragon that promises to “eat your fears”.

The two reach Thailand where they meet Jon (Tom Brittney), who after telling them all the things that could go wrong, agrees to take them on the hike. As the trio set out, after an equipment check complete with radios, cans of oxygen for altitude sickness, sturdy ropes and harnesses, we settle down to an icy clutch of dread.

Things rapidly go wrong, with rain, landslides, broken steps and chains. While there is much in the movie that reminds one of *Fall*, the film is clever enough to keep us off-kilter with the callbacks. The sight of a vulture eating a dead animal reminds you of the earlier film and gets you wondering if someone will soon have to make a meal of the carrion bird.

When a character falls off the trail, you wonder if they are dead, and when they are hauled back you question reality. Are they really saved or is it all survivor’s guilt. While *Fall* was stark desert with a needle in the sky, *Fall*

2 is lush greenery and an uncompromising, towering lump of rock.

There are thrills aplenty with planks, safety chains and sundry nuts and bolts coming loose, as the characters make one dubious decision after another. Introducing drug smuggling in the third act dilutes *Fall 2: Deadpoint*’s pure survival-thriller vibe. Shifting from nature as an implacable foe to human adversaries does the sequel no favours.

Slater and Thomas are completely committed to their roles and are rewarded for their good work with our hearts taking up permanent residency in our throats.

Fall 2: Deadpoint ends with a mention of Hell’s Chasm which is presumably where the third film will be set with Mann returning to directing duties. One only wishes the girls would take a parachute the next time they plan a vertiginous climb.

Fall 2: Deadpoint is currently running in theatres.

Snippets



Dhruv Vikram next will be Jackie

Tamil actor Dhruv Vikram is all set to headline an upcoming film titled *Jackie*, the makers announced on Sunday, September 13, with a first-look poster.

Produced by Mythri Movie Makers, the film is directed by Karan Arvind Kumar, who worked as an assistant director under writer-director RJ Balaji. The first-look poster featuring Dhruv blends live-action with a stylish comic-book-inspired aesthetic. The tagline ‘No Retakes Allowed’ suggests an edgy action film on cards. Details regarding the plot and the rest of the cast remain unknown. With music scored by Santhosh Narayanan, the upcoming film has cinematography by Viki and editing by Jayasuriya. Renowned action choreographer Vikram Mor is designing the film’s action sequences.



Anurag Kashyap-backed children’s film locks release date

Anurag Kashyap-backed children’s film, *Little Thomas* will be out in theatres on October 23, the makers announced on September 12.

Directed by Kaushal Oza, the film stars Gulshan Devaiah, Rasika Dugal and Hridansh Parekh in pivotal roles. Set in the Goa of the 1990s, the film follows Thomas, the only child of his parents, who desperately wants a little brother. Speaking about the film, Gulshan said in a statement, “It’s a heartwarming story of a simple family from Goa and it’s been very fulfilling to do this film. Being a part of the amazing works built by Kaushal Oza and sharing the screen with Rasika Duggal was a very memorable experience.”



Vijay Sethupathi-starrer Maharaja to be remade in Hollywood

Vijay Sethupathi’s action-thriller, *Maharaja*, is set to be remade in Hollywood, becoming the first Tamil film to do so. The film is reportedly going on floors next year with Matthew McConaughey in talks to play the lead.

Maharaja producer Sudhan Sundaram confirmed the news, saying that the makers are setting up the project with an A-list star after being approached by a Hollywood agency for remake rights. This comes after the film did well at the box office in China, earning ₹91.65 crore as per *Sacnilk*.

Directed by Nithilan Swaminathan, *Maharaja* also starred Anurag Kashyap in a negative role.



Toledo Truth Teller’s latest exploits

The Office spinoff continues to float by on charm and good vibes as it dives enthusiastically into podcasts and potholes

Streaming

Mini Anthikad Chhibber

mini.chhibber@thehindu.co.in

At the end of Season 1 of *The Office* spinoff, *The Paper*, the *Toledo Truth Teller* had won three awards and Ned (Domhnall Gleeson) the editor, and Mare (Chelsea Frei), the star reporter, had admitted their feelings for each other, though Ned was worried about the future.

The newspaper shares office space and volunteer journalists with Softees, a toilet paper brand, that sells much more than the *Toledo Truth Teller*. Season 2 opens with Ned hoping to ask the CEO, Marv (Allan Havey) for money to run the paper as it has won awards, something it has not done since the 1970s.

However, he is unable to do so as an employee of Softees dies and Marv wants the team to work on the obituary. When it turns out the employee was killed cooking meth, there is considerable cooling off and the wake is turned into a celebration of the awards.

Following the beats of a crisis being

The Paper Season 2

Creators: Greg Daniels & Michael Koman

Cast: Domhnall Gleeson, Sabrina Impacciatore, Chelsea Frei, Melvin Gregg, Gbemisola Ikumelo, Alex Edelman, Ramona Young, Tim Key, Oscar Nunez

Episodes: 10

Storyline: Winning awards is not enough to win friends and influence people as Ned and company realise

introduced and resolved in 25 minutes feels oddly reassuring in these uncertain times. While not hectically funny or heavy-duty serious, *The Paper* works because it is deeply invested in characters who feel like people we have all met in the course of our working lives. There are charming relationship dramas happening throughout the 10 episodes of *The Paper*.

We see Ned and Mare try to keep their relationship secret. Detrick (Melvin Gregg) the sales rep and Nicole (Ramona Young) from circulation move further away from each other. Their case is not helped by Lisa (Lisa Gilroy) from HR.

Travis (Eric Rahill) has a crisis of confidence when he feels he is not a real journalist, but Ned sees the quality of his photographs and hires him as a photojournalist. While covering a tornado with Adelola (Gbemisola Ikumelo) he discovers he has feelings for her.

Esmeralda Grand (Sabrina Impacciatore), the loud and flamboyant editor of TTT online, is up to her usual tricks, embarrassing her son and getting things gloriously wrong, including mistaking a halfway house for a haunted house.

Oscar Martinez (Oscar Nunez), from Dunder Mifflin, is making tough deals for his award-winning Suduko puzzle while

Barry (Duane Shepard Sr.) continues to drag himself out of senility to make the occasional sharp observation.

There is a charm about *The Paper* that allows it to sail by on good humour and vibes powered largely by Gleeson, who as a co-worker tells him looks like “someone drew David Bowie from memory.” There is something sweet about Ned pretending a rat bit him rather than admit to Mare, who was a war correspondent in the Army, that the recoil of the gun startled him.

The new billboard celebrating TTT’s victory at the awards, which results in cancelled subscriptions because people call the number on the billboard, is just the sort of mess the beleaguered paper would get into.

The episodes move quickly and we are invested enough in the relationships and career decisions of these harmless, delightful office folk to want to know what fresh trouble the good people of TTT will get into.

Hopefully, the third season will let us know, as Detrick wisely says, “I have a sixth sense about these things... not the Bruce Wills movie although I can tell when people are dead too.”

The Paper currently streams on JioHotstar